DETECT MAGIC (5E, 2024 RULES) – DESCRIPTION

Level 1 – Divination (ritual)
Casting Time: **Action** or **Ritual** · Range: **Self** (30-foot radius)
Components: **V, S** · Duration: **Concentration**, up to 10 minutes
Classes: Bard, Cleric, Druid, Paladin, Ranger, Sorcerer, Wizard

For the duration, you sense the presence of **magical effects** within 30 feet of you. If you sense such effects, you can take the **Magic** action to see a **faint aura** around any **visible** creature or object in the area that bears the magic. If the effect was created by a spell, you learn that spell's **school of magic**.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. You sense magic within 30 ft: its **presence**, not its position.
2. With the **Magic** action, you see the aura of whatever is **visible**.
3. You learn the school **only** if the effect comes from a spell.
4. The spell is **blocked** by stone, dirt, wood, metal, or lead.

⚠ Barriers:

- 1 foot of stone, dirt, or wood.
- 1 inch of metal.
- A thin sheet of lead.

⚠ Change from 2014

The spell detects **magical effects** (not "magic"). The school is revealed only if the effect comes from a spell. It requires the **Magic** action. Wood and dirt block at 1 foot (3 feet in 2014).

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The text leaves gray areas: is a magic item a "magical effect"? Does an illusion give off an aura? Fix: the **DM announces the calls before the game**.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe magic as a tingle or warmth from one direction, then a colored glow around the object when the aura is revealed.

Step 1 – Cast the spell:

Use an **action**, or a **ritual** (10 extra minutes, no spell slot). Components V, S. The spell requires your **concentration**, including while casting the ritual.

Step 2 – Sense the magic:

Within 30 ft, you sense the **presence** of magical effects. You know something is there, but not where.

Step 3 – See the auras:

Take the **Magic** action: you see a faint aura around any **visible** creature or object in the area that bears the magic. If the effect comes from a spell, you learn its **school**.

Step 4 – Check the barriers:

1 foot of stone, dirt, or wood, 1 inch of metal, or a sheet of lead blocks the spell.

Example: Lysa casts the spell in a crypt. Behind an 8-inch stone wall, she still senses the magic. Behind 16 inches of stone, she senses nothing.

Step 5 – End of the spell:

- The spell lasts **10 minutes** at most.
- It ends if your concentration is broken: damage with a failed Constitution saving throw, or the Incapacitated or Unconscious condition.
- You can recast the spell to keep searching.

DETECT MAGIC (5E, 2024 RULES) – Q&A AND DEBATE

Answers follow the 2024 text. Where the text is silent, the DM decides.

Is a spell that needs concentration detected as such?

The spell can tell you a magical effect is active nearby, but not that someone is concentrating on it.

Does it detect golems and other constructs?

It detects magical effects currently in place. The DM decides whether a construct's stat block includes one. Table rule

What school does a magic item have?

Only an effect created by a spell reveals a school. For an item the text is silent: the DM decides. Table rule

Does it detect a spell scroll, a spellbook, a +1 sword?

A spell scroll and a +1 weapon are magic items. An ordinary spellbook is not, unless it bears a magical effect. Table rule

Can I see an aura around an illusion?

The aura appears around a **visible** creature or object. You still sense the magic: the DM decides for a pure illusion. Table rule

Can I detect a creature made invisible by a spell?

You sense a presence, not its location. The creature must be visible for you to see its aura.

Does it reveal an item's properties or curse?

No. It only reveals that a magical effect is present. See the **Magic Items** sheet.

Do I concentrate while casting it as a ritual?

Yes: the spell requires concentration while the ritual is cast, then for its duration. Table rule

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Telling if an effect is magical

The game text says whether an effect is magical. Effects from spells and magic items always are.

Ritual and concentration

Cast as a Ritual, a Concentration spell needs concentration during casting if it takes longer than one action; afterward only if its duration requires it.

Concentration: range and sight

To keep concentrating, you don't need to stay in range or keep the spell in sight, unless stated otherwise.

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